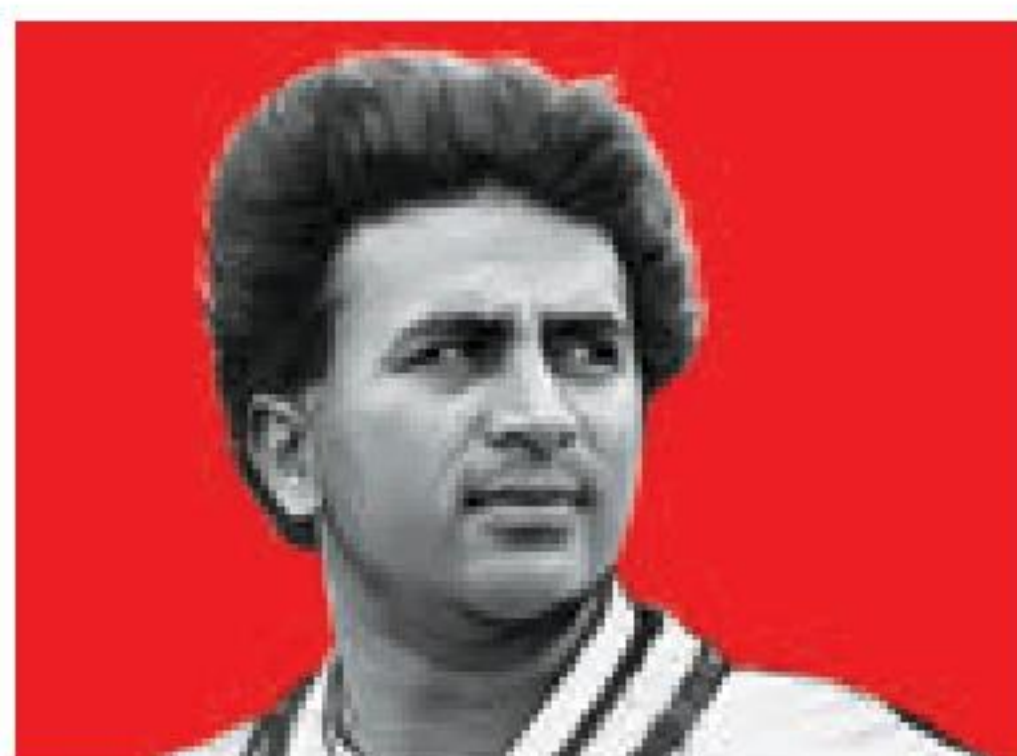




ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



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RAJAT PATIDAR'S CAPTAINCY WAS BEFITTING OF A CHAMPION TEAM

In a format where **fortunes can change** virtually every over, the standout captains were Patidar, Shreyas Iyer and Shubman Gill.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) winning the Indian Premier League (IPL) for the second time did not come as a surprise at all. Out of all the 10 participating teams, they looked the most well-oiled machine. They had batting depth, they had variety in their bowling, and their fielding was vastly better than that of other teams in a season where some simple catches were grassed. Above all, it was the captaincy of Rajat Patidar that got the team to gel in a manner that was befitting a champion team. They were not dependent on any one player, and the fact that eight different players from their team won the 'Player of the Match' in the tournament shows that.

If the 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi was the standout player with the bat with his

awe-inspiring six-hitting ability, it was the 36-year-old Bhuvneshwar Kumar who once again showed that you do not need express pace but clever variations in this format to take wickets. There were some acrobatic catches taken but also some easy ones missed, which invariably turned the course of the game as the reprieved batter capitalised on his escape to make a telling difference.

In a format where the fortunes can change virtually every over, the standout captains were Patidar, Shreyas Iyer, and Shubman Gill. Not only did they perform splendidly with the bat, but they were razor sharp with their bowling changes and tactical moves. Captaincy can flower if the individual is doing well in his own speciality, and that is where perhaps Riyan Parag fell a bit short. With his own form not being consistent and with a leg injury at the

back of his mind, he wasn't able to lead with the sharpness that one associates with his game. Still, he is the one to keep an eye on, as he is a natural leader.

Captains and coaches are only as good as their teams, and the other skippers suffered because they didn't have talent in their squads that could play the decisive innings and bowl the devastating spell that changed the match their way.

A lot of the big hitters in the various State and city leagues that have sprouted up were exposed when faced with the international quality of bowling in the IPL. In the State and city leagues, the standard of both batting and bowling is nowhere near as good, and unless the scouts have a discerning eye and don't get swayed by player agents, the franchises will keep picking players based on these